CYBERCAB FLEET OWNERS · PUBLIC EDITION

Funding & Depreciation

How a Cybercab fleet can be funded on its cash flows , and how the funding plan lowers depreciation

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Written by the expert team of the Tesla Cybercab Fleet Owners community , based on Michiel van Duijn's presentation in Robotaxi Countdown episode 39

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Where this comes from
Robotaxi Countdown episode 39 (Tesla to Mars podcast , May 2025) , with Michiel van Duijn , a funding specialist with years of experience funding a large Tesla lease fleet : https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2GpLG7RqqTk . Announced on X by the host : https://x.com/KRoelandschap/status/1922965351513342377 . Paraphrased by us ; timestamps refer to the episode .

Before you read
Not financial advice . This guide describes structures , not an offer or an investment . Tesla has not published owner terms . This edition contains no return , yield , revenue or fee figures .

CHAPTER 1

From lease to robotaxi

What decades of car leasing teach a robotaxi owner

For years , a lease car did one thing : take one driver to work and back . It stood still most of the day , and after four years it went to the second-hand market . A robotaxi breaks every one of those habits , and the way it is funded has to change with it .

What this chapter covers
Financial versus operational lease · Why one car per customer was easy to fund · What changes with a robotaxi

This chapter covers how car fleets are funded today , why that worked , and what a robotaxi changes .

Proof point 1 : two kinds of lease
Financial lease : only financing · Operational lease : a full mobility service

Michiel van Duijn explains the difference (around 3:50) : a financial lease is only financing , paid in instalments ; an operational lease is a full-service package where the leasing company takes care of everything . Business clients mostly choose operational lease .

Proof point 2 : one car , one customer
Low maintenance for the funder · Long contracts , known drivers

Lease fleets of thousands of cars were manageable because each car had one customer on a contract of four or five years (around 33:30) . Funders knew who drove and what came in each month .

Proof point 3 : the four-year habit
Cars returned after about four years · Sold to the second-hand market abroad · Yet they can drive 8 to 10 years

Leasing companies usually took cars back after about four years and sold them on , even though the cars could easily drive eight to ten years (around 20:20) . That habit made depreciation look larger than it needs to be .

Depreciation per km

The one metric in this guide · set by the price of the car , its life and how it is funded

Wider than cars
Robots and other autonomous assets · The same funding question

The hosts point out that the same funding question will come back for other autonomous machines , such as humanoid robots . The structure in this guide is meant to be reusable .

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CHAPTER 2

Why lenders look backwards

Asset-backed lending and its limits

A bank looks at a car and asks two things : what is it worth if we take it back , and who signed the contract . A robotaxi has no fixed driver and earns per ride . Neither question has a familiar answer .

What this chapter covers
How asset-backed funding works · Why ride-hailing cash flows look risky to banks · The call for more risk appetite

This chapter covers the traditional structure , why ride-hailing income does not fit it , and what kind of funder is needed instead .

Proof point 1 : the ring-fenced asset company
A separate holding company owns the cars · Long-term lease contracts secure the cash flow

In the traditional structure (around 41:30) the cars sit in a separate , ring-fenced company . Its long-term lease contracts plus the cars themselves secure the bank's money .

Proof point 2 : flexible income is not favoured
Variable ride-hailing income · Frequent changes of user

Ride-hailing income changes every day and the users change constantly . Traditional asset-backed lenders do not favour that , because they lend on the value of the car combined with fixed receivables .

Proof point 3 : software as an accessory
Funders treated FSD as an add-on · No value for future capability

When the team asked funders how to treat self-driving software , the funders saw it as just an accessory to the car , like any other hardware option (around 18:20) .

Risk appetite

Quoting Matt Smith in the episode : funders are backward-looking , and a new model needs more risk appetite in the capital structure

What it means for your plan
Expect traditional lenders to ask for residual value · Prepare evidence of cash flows instead

When you talk to a lender , expect questions about residual value first . Bring the cost per kilometre sheet and any evidence of use , as described in chapter 7 of our implementation guide .

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CHAPTER 3

Depreciation : the biggest line

Why it is the largest cost , and why it is not fixed

Ask any fleet manager which cost hurts most , and the answer is the same : the car losing value . But how much value it loses depends less on the car than on the assumptions made when it was funded .

> **What this chapter covers**
> Hardware loses value , software may gain · The price ceiling set by new cars · Life in years and kilometres

This chapter covers the parts of depreciation , the limit on any value gain , and why life assumptions matter .

> **Proof point 1 : hardware down , software up**
> The car loses value · Self-driving software may become worth more

The team's early thinking (around 69:20) was that the car depreciates , while self-driving software may appreciate as it improves , so the combination could hold its value .

> **Proof point 2 : the ceiling**
> A used car is never worth more than a new one · New car prices cap the value of used cars

That only holds if new cars stop coming . If a new Cybercab or Model Y can be bought cheaply , a used car will never be worth more than that new price . The new vehicle price sets a ceiling .

> **Proof point 3 : it is about cash flow , not appreciation**
> The early idea was a fallacy · Future cash flows decide value

Their conclusion (around 64:35) : the value of the car's resale is not the point . What matters is the cash the car can generate in its life . A purpose-built Cybercab may generate more than a used Model Y .

Life , not resale

Depreciation per km falls when the write-off is spread over the real life of the car

> **Wider than one car**
> Cheaper cars help the whole model · Second-hand prices in Europe are low

Lower purchase cost improves everything downstream . Second-hand Tesla prices in Europe are lower than in the US , which the episode sees as a window , as long as the car meets the network's hardware rules .

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CHAPTER 4

Lowering depreciation through the funding plan

The expert team's solution , as presented by Michiel van Duijn

Two leasing companies sell the same self-driving package . One writes it down to zero in five years and charges for that . The other assumes a realistic life and shares the upside . The second offer is far cheaper per month , for the same car .

What this chapter covers
Write off over the real life · Fund the appreciating part separately · Fund on cash flows , not residual value · Lower the purchase cost

This chapter covers the four parts of the funding plan that lower depreciation cost per kilometre .

Part 1 : write off over the real life
Not to zero over a 4 to 5 year lease · Spread over 8 to 10 years of use

Most leasing companies wrote the self-driving software down to zero over a 60-month contract . The team decided not to depreciate it fully , and to assume the cars , and the software , last eight to ten years (around 14:57 to 20:50) . That was the basis for a much lower monthly price for customers .

Part 2 : split the asset
Hardware : traditional asset-backed funding · Software : funders who share the upside , at low cost

The team proposed funding the self-driving part separately , with investors who understand its value can rise , potentially at a lower interest rate , in exchange for a share of the upside (around 18:40) . The deal did not go through then , but it was the first step to treating the car as a possibly appreciating asset .

Part 3 : fund on cash flows , not residual value
Interest linked to the value of the car · Plus a share of ride revenue · The car repays its own loan

For robotaxis , Michiel van Duijn's structure (around 43:00) combines traditional asset-based interest with a revenue share : the car earns on the network and part of that income repays the loan . Because the funding follows future cash flows instead of residual value , a low resale price no longer drives the cost .

Part 4 : lower the capex
A cheaper car lowers depreciation per km · Buy within network hardware rules

The business works much better with a lower purchase cost , whether a low-cost Cybercab or a suitable used car . Any used car must meet the network's hardware requirements , and its mileage adds maintenance and risk .

Cash flow , not residual value

The core idea : who funds the car , and on what basis , changes the largest cost line

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CHAPTER 5

A fund built on cash flows

CyberFund : linking investors and shepherds

Someone holds Tesla shares and wants income they can actually spend . Somewhere else , a shepherd wants ten cars but has no bank willing to lend . A fund in the middle could connect the two .

What this chapter covers
The fund structure · Who the investors could be · Starting size and scaling

This chapter covers the fund Michiel van Duijn describes , who might invest , and why it needs a minimum size .

Proof point 1 : investors with a Tesla mindset
Retail and community investors · Institutions and , later , banks

The fund would link investors from the Tesla community , retail or institutional , and eventually banks once they see the cash flows , to the shepherds who run the cars (around 27:30) .

Proof point 2 : the inverse of the stock
Monthly cash flow instead of share price · Diversification for long-term shareholders

He describes the fund as the inverse of holding the stock : instead of value that is not liquid , monthly cash flows from cars on the network .

Proof point 3 : a minimum scale
Setting up and running a fund costs money · Start at a meaningful size , grow each quarter

His model starts at a fund size large enough to cover its own running costs , then grows each quarter . A pipeline on both sides , capital and shepherds , must be matched so money does not sit idle .

Matched pipelines

Capital on one side , vetted shepherds on the other

Wider than robotaxis
Community or municipal funds · The same model for other robots

The hosts sketch funds in which residents of a city co-own a local fleet , so the cash flows stay in the community . The same idea could fund fleets of other robots .

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CHAPTER 6

Shepherds and the division of labour

Who does what in the structure

A shepherd in the US told the team how many cars he could run with one extra employee . His answer shaped the whole model : not one owner with one car , but layers of shepherds .

What this chapter covers
How many cars one shepherd runs · A lean fund · Tesla's role

This chapter covers the operating layers , what the fund itself should and should not do , and where Tesla fits .

Proof point 1 : about ten cars per shepherd
One shepherd ≈ 10 cars · A master shepherd ≈ 70 cars with one employee

A US fleet builder estimated each local shepherd could manage about ten cars , and he himself about seventy with one employee (around 32:25) . At large production volumes , that means a very large number of shepherds is needed .

Proof point 2 : a lean fund
Match capital with shepherds · Vet shepherds , possibly with AI · Nothing more

The fund should be efficient and limited to putting capital to work : matching funds with shepherds and vetting them against clear criteria . Fleet operations , utilisation and car sourcing are delegated to the shepherd .

Proof point 3 : a mix of owners
About one third Tesla · One third private shepherds · One third professional fleets and lessors

The hosts expect a large fleet to be split roughly into thirds between Tesla , private shepherds with one to ten cars , and professional fleet owners or lease companies .

10 cars

Rough number one shepherd can manage , according to a US fleet builder in the episode

What it means for your plan
Decide your layer · Build evidence for funders

Decide whether you want to be a shepherd , a fleet company or an investor . Funders will ask for a list of shepherds , letters of intent and unit economics before committing .

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CHAPTER 7

Risks , timing and what to watch

Wait , prepare , or both

Everyone in the room agrees on two things : robotaxis are coming , and they will need funding . On almost everything else , there is uncertainty that may take months or years to clear .

What this chapter covers
Investor risks · Operator risks · The prepare-now case

This chapter covers the main risks , when to act , and what to do in the meantime .

Risk 1 : the network's rules
Which cars are allowed , and when · Hardware level requirements

A used car bought too early may not be allowed on the network for a year , and would then compete with it on other platforms . Buy only cars that meet the hardware requirements .

Risk 2 : unknown economics
Wait and see how the network ramps

From an investor's view , Michiel van Duijn would wait to see real economics before committing capital . He calls himself more risk-averse than operators who buy now .

Risk 3 : the price ceiling and falling values
New car prices cap used values · Fast production may push prices down

Fast production of new cars caps what any used car is worth , which limits value-based strategies .

Prepare now , commit on evidence

Structure ready , capital matched to real unit economics

What it means for your plan
Have the structure ready · Collect interest and evidence · Not financial advice

The hosts argue for having the structure ready now , so capital can move once the numbers are known . This guide describes structures , not investments . Not financial advice .

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Discuss this guide with future owners , shepherds and funders :

X community
https://x.com/i/communities/1912893645050511710

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